# THE PRINCE, THE PAINTER, AND THE PRIESTS

In March 1597, as the excitement of the Nauroz celebrations gripped the city of Lahore, a catastrophic blaze, possibly caused by a lightning bolt, broke out in the palace. The tents set up in the courtyard caught fire and the flames then spread to Akbar's quarters. As the servants and courtiers watched helplessly, the roaring flames burnt to ashes the pavilion of Salim, then spread from tent to tent, till the wooden structures of Akbar's palace were crackling and crashing in the cool spring air. The fire burnt uncontrolled for two days at the end of which a throne of gold had been melted down, as had 'large quantities of draperies of cloth of gold and silk'. What distressed Akbar the most, wrote the Jesuits, 'was the loss of all his treasures, both those which he had inherited from his ancestors, and those he had amassed during his own reign'. Immediately after this disaster, Akbar decided to leave Lahore for Kashmir. Even Abu'l Fazl admitted that the Padshah now had no wish to remain in the city to celebrate the Nauroz festival and that the only way that Akbar could deal with his grief was to gather his harem and his men and leave.

Before leaving for Kashmir, Akbar decided to send the twenty-five-year-old Daniyal away from the imperial court, for the first time, to Allahabad. Daniyal was made a Hafthazari*, and given many honours. Qulij Khan was appointed as ataliq. As he had done for Murad, Akbar gave Daniyal a long list of instructions and advice. The Padshah reiterated the need for temperance, moderation, measured action, and clemency. Akbar stressed repeatedly the wisdom in surrounding oneself with worthy people and underlined the need to gauge the true nature of people. 'Consider nobility of caste and high birth as an outcome of a person's character, rather than goodness inherited from grandfathers or the greatness of the family,' wrote Akbar to his son. 'You can understand this truth by knowing that although smoke comes from fire, it has no light.' These were truths that Akbar had crafted his empire upon—the ability to judge men of talent beyond their dubious births and uncertain pedigrees; the vast confidence to promote men from outside the orthodox Muslim Sunni fold, and the iron strength with which to bestow clemency and forgiveness on those deserving